



Child's Play

If you wonder what on earth, apart from the telly can keep your kids entertained through the long afternoons, then read on

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Picture this: you are running late for that dentist's appointment, the *ayah* is on leave, and your bundle of joy's shrieking like a banshee. His favourite cartoons won't start for another three hours, and he is as pesky as they come. You *have* got a computer, an Internet connection, a filter—the works, you

know. The Internet is full of sites unsuitable for kids (and some adults, for that matter) but if you know what you are looking for, you'll find places that are tailor-made for impressionable minds—kids, in short. These Websites provide a combination of education and entertainment which are designed keeping in mind the notoriously short attention span of so many children.

National Geographic Kids

(<http://kids.nationalgeographic.com/>)

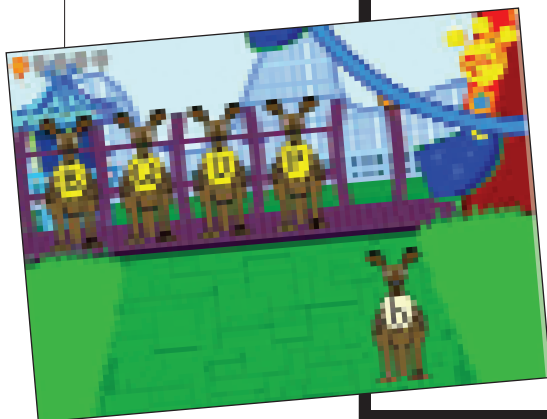


National Geographic has been in the edutainment business for long, and needs no introduction. National Geographic's child-oriented publication—National Geographic Kids—is known for its child-specific content, and the Web site is an appropriate complement to the magazine.

This site has games, videos and activities, most of them themed around animals past and present. They have videos on prehistoric sea monsters—a complete explanation which will hopefully stop all those questions your daughter had about those giant crocodiles in *Ice Age 2*. Related activities could be constructing a toothpick model or understanding how fossils are formed. There are a lot of Flash-based games on offer—play Frisbee with the dolphins, or plug holes in a leaky pipe, so a thirsty pup gets water in his bowl. NGK also has an option where children can personalise their homepages, send e-cards to buddies or test new games before they are rolled out. Get cracking!

GameGoo

(<http://www.cogcon.com/gamegoo/config.html>)



The baby kangaroos at Paw Park can't find their fathers, so it's up to you to help them—the babies are wearing t-shirts with lowercase alphabets on them, and their fathers are wearing t-shirts with uppercase alphabets. This is one of the many games at GameGoo that will keep your pre-schooler enthralled. This site's motto is "Learning that Sticks"—too bad we didn't have a pre-schooler at hand who could have proved it, but we guess the site does its job pretty well. GameGoo focuses on language skills like antonyms and synonyms, spellings, sentence construction—all the things that are taught in prep school. Brightly coloured animated characters feature in the games, which are divided into three levels—depending on how advanced the concepts taught are. Children are bound to outgrow the site quickly, but whatever they learn will have been learned well. And this is almost redundant, but there will be peace and quiet in the house—maybe a few excited giggles and claps, but definitely no bawling.